A War Worth Fighting

By Clyde Hendrickson

The Needlenorfs were fighting the Bonglejohns. The Bonglejohns were fighting the Needlenorfs. This is how it was, and how it always had been. The Bonglejohns would hurl a barrage of flaming hamsters at the Needlenorfs, and the Needlenorfs would, in turn, fire back with a volley of flaming guinea pigs. One side would retreat, and the other would charge, only to be turned away again by a counter offensive. Neither side ever actually won any real victory. All in all, it was a pretty good way of life for these dwarf tribes in mysterious lands.

As far back as either group could remember, neither side could remember what they were fighting for. Their father had fought in the great war, just as his father before him, just as his mother and father and aunts and uncles before him. Today, a Needlenorf or a Bonglejohn had it pretty sweet: Get up in the morning, light a few rodents on fire, toss them over a hill at the enemy, and go about your business. Sure, there was the occasional rain of ashes and crispy critters, but one got used to such things when living in such a set way of life. In fact, many dwarves made their living cleaning up the debris of the war or selling flame-retardant clothing.

Few of the tribespeople actually belonged to the army. Oh sure, there were some generals and colonels to command the large attacks and keep things running smoothly, but there was little need for foot soldiers. Each citizen was expected to do his or her part by throwing a few blazing hot animals at the enemy each week, thus avoiding a requirement for a real military. These rules also made it unnecessary for anyone to actually risk their life in battle. Indeed, no one had been killed in the great war for 20 years, the last casualty being a Bonglejohn who's guinea pig exploded while still in his hand. It was, literally, a very civil war.

Very civil to everyone, that is, except Tom. The war between the Needlenorfs and the Bonglejohns horrified Tom. He was disgusted by their senseless fighting, and the thought of lighting a living creature on fire made his stomach churn. Tom had stumbled upon this violent hellhole when, one day, he had opened an odd wardrobe in his room and been sucked into the dwarves' mysitc land. There was a wooden sign where he landed, with two arrows. One was labeled NARNIA, the other VIOLENT HELLHOLE. Choosing not to see poor old Aslan the lion skinned again, Tom followed the latter and ended up in the middle of the great war.

At first, Tom was simply shocked by the attitude the tribes had towards war. What ancient dispute could be so vital as to cause every man, woman, and child to take up arms against the enemy every day of their lives? Puzzled, Tom went to see the chief of each tribe. At the Needlenorf headquarters, he met Cid, the highest ranking general in their army. He inquired Cid as to what the reasons behind the war could be, saying,

"Why, pray tell, are you fighting the Bonglejohns?"

` Cid thought for a moment, then responded,

"What's it to you, fathead?"

"I was just wondering. How could you possibly justify such bloody combat?"

"Bloody combat?" Cid looked around in horror. "There's bloody combat? Where?"

"Out there, on the battlefield."

"There's blood on our battlefield? What type?"

"Well, it's red…"

"Oh. It's probably barbecue sauce. We had a lovely festival the other day with lots of roast chicken."

Tom couldn't believe his ears. "You had a barbecue on a battlefield? In the middle of a war? What kind of sick barbarians are you?! I mean, didn't people get hurt?"

"Why, no one's been killed in this war for twenty years! Why should there be any deaths now?"

"Because you spend all day hurling flaming rodents at each other?"

"Actually, it doesn't really hurt to get hit by one. You should try it some time – it's actually kind of fun. Sort of like being in a food fight, but with more dead animals."

Afer letting out a cry of frustration, Tom stormed out of the room, convinced that General Cid was suffering form post-war hallucinations. He immediately crossed over to the Bonglejohn's territory, carefully avoiding the front lines, hoping to get more sense out of their leader. He found this rather large dwarf in his tent, careful brooding over a ham sandwich. Tom greeted him as politely as he could, trying to remember if he had learned any dwarf etiquette in manners class.

"Good day, general…"

" Dys," He mumbled through bites of ham and lettuce.

"Good day, General Dys. I would like to ask you a few questions."

"No questions. Eating."

"Yes, well, I wonder if you could just take a short break and help me out with something."

"No helping. Eating."

Tom took a deep breath, than began again in earnest. "Actually, sir, if I may be blunt, it looks like you're just staring at your food, and not actually eating it."

"Am I? I hadn't noticed." With those words, the general stuffed the entire sandwich in his mouth and swallowed. Tom recovered quickly, returning to his purpose.

"General, I have one question for you: why are you fighting this war?"

"What war?" Dys looked genuinely concerned.

"Uh, the one between you and the Needlenorfs. You hurl flaming guinea pigs at them every day."

"Really? Is that a war? I always thought they were just in need of some flaming guinea pigs, and we were trading them for some charred hamsters."

"Well sir, it is a war, and I want some answers about it. You are a general, after all."

"Am I? I hadn't noticed." With these words, the general promptly began ordering his men around like a proper military officer. Some hope returned to Tom.

"So, general, why are you fighting this war?"

"I don't know, but I kind of like the basic idea. It's fun ordering these guys around."

"No, it's not fun at all, it's serious business! You're sending these men to their deaths!"

"My men are dying? Where?"

"Everywhere! They're all being stuck by the flying rodent debris."

"When's the last time you saw a dead furry animal actually hurt someone?"

"Well, it's the idea that they *could* be dying that's important. It is the thought that counts, you know."

"Mister, I suggest you stop stirring up trouble, or I may be forced to smack you upside the head with my ham sandwich."

"But you ate your ham sandwich."

The general stared daggers into Tom, as though he had just stolen his last sandwich. "It's the thought that counts," he growled.

A week passed after Tom's first encounter with the generals, and he returned to the real world to do some serious thinking. Tom did his thinking best in his thinking room, located in a secluded part of his house. This thinking room was, in actuality, a closet filled with Tom's cheese grater collection, and it gave him no extra mental abilities whatsoever. Tom's friends had always wanted to tell him this, but, unfortunately, he had no friends.

For days at a time, Tom thought. He went without meals, without sleep, and, horribly, without television. There seemed to be no way to resolve the war between the dwarves. Suddenly, while staring at a meat colored cheese grater, Tom had a revelation. He would strike the generals in their most vulnerable areas: their stomachs. Filled with a renewed sense of purpose, Tom set out to end the great war.

Back in the land through the wardrobe, General Cid was enjoying a tunafish salad sandwich when Tom walked in. Resisting the urge to immediately light the sandwich on fire and throw it at the intruder, the general sat back and listened to Tom's plan. Tom began in a friendly tone.

"General, I think we got off on the wrong foot. I'd like to think we could still become friends."

"Okay."

"Great! And as a token of my friendship, I would like to invite you to a barbecue on top of Mt. Sunnymore tomorrow afternoon."

"Can I light the dead animals on fire?"

"Uh, Sure."

"I'll be there."

Tom left feeling more confident than ever that his plan would succeed. He just hoped that General Dys would be as cooperative as his Needlenorf counterpart. That night, he found the Bonglejohn leader outside his command post, staring at the night sky. The general spoke as Tom approached.

"They're beautiful, aren't they?"

"Excuse me?"

"The stars. They look like a million little flaming guinea pigs."

"Uh, Yes, Yes they do."

"Wouldn't it be wonderful to live up there among them? I bet that's what heaven's like, with blazing rodents as far as the eyes can see."

"Anyway, general, I think we kind of got off to a bad start the other day."

"I've met you before?"

"Yes, we had an argument about the war."

"What war?"

"The war that – Oh, anyhow, I want to invite you to a barbecue tomorrow afternoon on Mt. Sunnymore. Can you come?"

"May I light the dead animals on fire?"

"Sure thing."

"I'll be there, if I remember. If only I had someone to write it down for me."

"You're a general, remember? Order someone to do it."

"Ah yes! What would I do without you, Tom?"

"Uh, I don't know, sir."

"Well, I do. I would light guinea pigs on fire and hurl them towards the sky. Good day."

Tom was ecstatic - the plan was working perfectly. The only thing left was the barbecue itself, and he had quite a lunch in store for the generals.

The weather on Mt. Sunnymore was quite balmy, because there were always barbecues on Mt. Sunnymore. The weather was so nice for grilling there. Tom set up a large picnic table with room for his two guests and all the fried dead animals they could ever want. These unfortunate creatures were laid out on the ground – pigs, chickens, turkeys, ducks, cows, and many others – ready to be barbecued on the giant gas grill next to them. It was going to be, Tom hoped, the best barbecue ever held on the mountain.

General Cid and General Dys arrived at almost the exact same time. After exchanging greetings and introductions, the two leaders sat down with Tom, who pored them each a glass of iced tea. Although they wasted away almost an hour with small talk, General Cid inevitably asked the wrong question:

"So, General Dys, what do you do for a living?"

"Well," replied the Bonglejohn, "I think I'm a general in the army"

"Which army?" inquired General Cid.

"The Bonglejohn army."

"Oh, that's nice," General Cid said with a faint smile. He then thought for a moment, looked at the other general and said with an expression of concern,

"I'm afraid I have to kill you now."

"So you must be in the Needlenorf army. That's a shame," remarked General Dys, "Well, I guess I have to kill you too. This is going to make a terrible mess. Tom, you must have known we were enemies. Why did you invite us both to the same barbecue?"

"Now just calm down. Nobody's going to kill anyone," Tom comforted the general, "In fact, I invited you both here in hopes we could end this horrible war."

"What?!" The generals shouted in unison.

"That's crazy," said General Dys, "I think you need some roasted animals to get your mental strength back."

"I agree. Let's light up those critters," concurred General Cid.

"No, I'm afraid I'll have to insist you sign this peace treaty first. It's very reasonable – all you have to do is stop throwing burning rodents at each other," Tom told them. He quickly produced the document from the pocket of his barbeque apron and was dismayed to see it had been stained by the sauce.

General Cid looked at the treaty and said,

"Can't we just burn a few animals before we sign it? Just looking at those stains makes me hungry."

"No treaty, no barbecue," replied Tom.

The Generals' eyes met, and they agreed in silence. Then, each stepped forward and signed the treaty.

For Tom, the next week flew by like a guinea pig with his hind end on fire. He just could not wait to go back to the newly pacified land of the dwarves . He envisioned that the land would have become a haven for all who lived there, filled with happiness, joy, and plenty of vegetarian meals. As he entered the wardrobe for what he hoped would be his last visit, Tom grabbed the two Cusinart toasters he had purchased as peace offerings for the generals.

For the Bonglejohns and the Needlenorfs, the first week of peace had crawled by like a guinea pig that had too much to drink the night before. All their industries had come to a halt after the treaty was signed; Almost every factory had a closed sign hanging in the window. The hamster and guinea pig breeders were especially hit hard, because, without the war, there was practically no demand for their furry product. Now, even the wives had to work just to put food on the table, and the food, much to the dwarves' disgust, usually consisted of very little charbroiled critter.

Tom was horrified at the scene when he arrived in Needlenorf territory. Many dwarves were lying homeless in the streets, their way of life gone. At first, Tom thought that the war had begun again, and that these destitute men must be the victims of ruthless attacks by the opposing army. However, the piles of unused guinea pigs at every corner told him otherwise. None of this, shocking as it was, prepared Tom for the sight that greeted him when he reached the border of Bonglejohn Territory. There, standing just inches away from each other, were the entire armies of both sides, staring desparingly at each other.

A soldier greeted him on the Bonglejohn side with forlorn eyes. He sat stroking a small hamster which resided in the palm of his hand. Choking back tears, he tried to express the complexities of his people's difficulties.

"This is just awful."

"Why?" Tom responed, "How can you despair in such joyous times?"

"Because I've lost my will to live."

"But you should be filled with new purpose now that the war is over and you can have a real life." The soldier seemed to take true offense at such a statement.

"Good sir, I have no life left."

"But there's no more war! I ended it myself."

"What you have ended was the most glorious, grandiose sport that a group of gentledwarves have ever taken the field to partake in. What you have decided in your rightousness to condemn has broken and destroyed all that was right in our land. Not to mention that our land is now overrun with hordes of absolutely untorched rodents. In fact, this one in my hand is downright room temperature. No sir, you have ended not a war but a world."

A now distraught Tom ran to the centrifuge of the two sides. He climbed upon a large boulder, and as he prepared to speak, General Dys and General Cid moved to the front of their respective lines.

"My friends, my allies, why have you started this awful war again?" He cried, "You were on the right path before. I beg you, please, return to a peaceful way of life. It will be better for you and your short, stubby families."

Both Generals explained to Tom that the war was the only source of economic prosperity for both the Bonglejohns and the Needlenorfs, as any idiot or well tuned reader could see by now. But Tom was adamant.

" I shall not leave this field by my own will until this war is over forever."

General Cid looked at General Dys. They exchanged a mutual glance, and then looked to their soldiers. Tom was quickly shoved into a catapult, lit on fire, and catapulted into the sky.

A romantic poet then appeared on the scene. When questioned as to his purpose, he replied,

"I'm here to illustrate the irony and metaphorical quality of these events." The Romantic poet was subsequently launched into the air aflame as well, and the symbolism was complete. The Bonglejohns and the Needlenorfs then proceeded to fight happily ever after.